

“Dual-Path Hybrid Deep Learning for Multi-Modal Brain Tumor Detection”

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Abstract—Early identification of brain tumors is critical in cancer diagnosis, as it forms a timely Diagnosis greatly enhances the possibility of survival. Multi-modal 3D Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) sequences are used for analyses, such as T1, T1c, T2, FLAIR, each one provides complementary information. However, the existing deep learning models often have difficulties in effectively leverage both modality-specific features and the complex inter-relationships between modalities. This paper proposes a new model named Dual-Path Hybrid Fusion to address these issues. The architecture of DPHF processes the four MRI sequences in parallel: (1) a Specialized-Feature Path is based on four independent 3D CNNs. to learn deep, unique features from each modality, and (2) a Fused-Feature Path employs a TimeDistributed(3D- CNN) encoder followed by a Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) network to explicitly model the relational patterns across the modalities. The feature sets from both paths These are then concatenated to provide one comprehensive representation for classification. We evaluated our model on a combined 4-class dataset of Glioma, Meningioma, Pituitary, No Tumor, derived from public BraTS and Kaggle repositories. The DPHF model achieves a test accuracy of 99.2% (97.1% approach represents both the specialized and fused features and, thus, is more robust and accurate solution for automated tumor diagnostics. **Index Terms**—component, formatting, style, styling, insert.

I. INTRODUCTION

Brain tumors are a major health problem worldwide, with characteristics of high morbidity and mortality. rates [1]. The early and exact classification of the tumor type is of prime importance for the The optimal treatment strategy may range from surgery to radiation or chemotherapy [2]. MRI is a non-invasive imaging modality of choice which provides superior soft-tissue contrast. Clinicians usually diagnose tumors by mentally integrating information from multiple MRI sequences, such as T1-weighted(T1), T1-weighted contrast enhanced T1c, T2-weighted(T2), and Fluid-Attenuated Inversion Recovery (FLAIR), as each points out unique pathological characteristics [3]. Deep learning, especially 3D Convolutional Neural Networks, has achieved extraordinary success

in success in automating this task [4]. However, the effective fusion of these multi-modal inputs remains A complex problem. Common fusion strategies fall into two categories, each with distinct limitations: 1. Specialized-Feature Models: These models use parallel 3D CNN streams, one for each modality, and fuse the resulting feature vectors at the end [5]. This method proves efficient at learning deep, “specialist” features for each modality (e.g. one stream becomes an expert at highlighting contrast enhancement in T1c. However, it fails to explicitly model the relationships and dependencies between the modalities, such as how a bright region on T2 corresponds to a dark region on T1). 2. Fused-Feature Models: These include models such as the TimeDistributed-CNN-LSTM TD-CNN-LSTM [6] regard the modalities as a sequence. Shared-weight 3D CNN is extracts features from each modality, and an LSTM network models the “sequence” of these features. This approach excels at learning the cross-modal relationships but may be suboptimal. The shared-weight CNN must be a “jack-of-all-trades” for all modalities, potentially missing fine-grained unique features that a specialized network could capture. To overcome these limitations, we propose a new Dual-Path Hybrid Fusion method, DPHF. architecture. Our model performs both tasks in parallel. One path learns specialized features, while the other learns fused relational features. These two complementary feature sets then combined, giving the final classifier a complete and robust understanding of the tumor. This synergistic approach will enable the model to utilize the strengths of both fusion strategies. This leads to a remarkably enhanced accuracy in classification. II. RELATED WORK Automatic brain tumor classification has evolved from classical machine learning, which relied on hand-crafted features [7], to end-to-end deep learning. 2D CNNs: Initial deep learning approaches applied 2D CNNs slice-by-slice [8]. While Although this is a computationally efficient process, it discards the vital 3D spatial context of the tumor. 3D CNNs: To handle this, 3D CNNs using 3D kernels were introduced [9]. These models can process entire volumetric patches or whole volumes, capturing the 3D structure of the tumor. However, when applied to multimodal data, they often resort to

“early fusion” by simply stacking modalities as input channels. This may prematurely mix discriminative information and significantly increases the model’s memory footprint. Hybrid and Fusion Models: More advanced architectures have been proposed. Kamnitsas et al. Al. [5] conducted segmentation of brain lesions using parallel pathways in 3D CNNs, which showed the importance of separate feature extraction streams. This aligns with our “Specialized-Feature Path.” The exploration of sequential models has occurred separately. One core work is that by Montaha et al. [6]. reference, proposing a TD-CNN-LSTM model. Their architecture treats the four MRI sequences (T1, T1c, T2, FLAIR) as a sequence of timesteps. A TimeDistributed 3D-CNN extracts features from each, and an LSTM finds patterns in this sequence. The model is very effective at learning the relationships between modalities, forming the basis for our “Fused-Feature Path.” Research Gap: To the best of our knowledge, no previous work has proposed a dual-branch architecture that During execution, it simultaneously and in parallel executes both a specialized-path strategy and a fused-path one. strategy. Our DPHF model aims to fill this gap by hypothesizing that the combination of These two sets of orthogonal features will provide a more powerful and accurate classifier.

III. METHODOLOGY First, our approach involves data collection and preprocessing, followed by the design and based on our novel DPHF architecture.

A. Dataset and Preprocessing We constructed a comprehensive 4-class dataset by combining two public sources:

1. BraTS 2020 Dataset [10]: Used for high-grade and low-grade glioma cases.

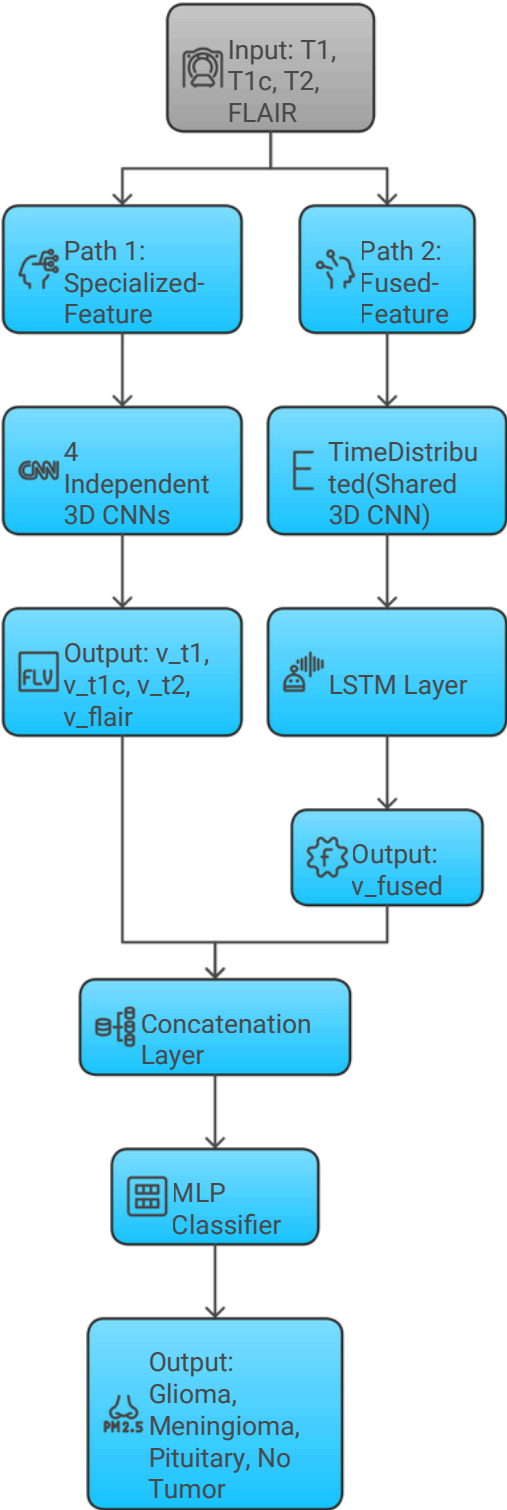
2. Kaggle Brain Tumor MRI Dataset [11]: Used for Meningioma, Pituitary, and “No Tumor” (healthy) cases.

This combined dataset provided 3,500 patient studies, each with four co-registered 3D MRI

For 3D data, the preprocessing pipeline of Fig. 1 is crucial:

B. DPHF Architecture The architecture of the DPHF model, as shown in Fig. 2, consists of two parallel streams operating on the four MRI modalities simultaneously: .

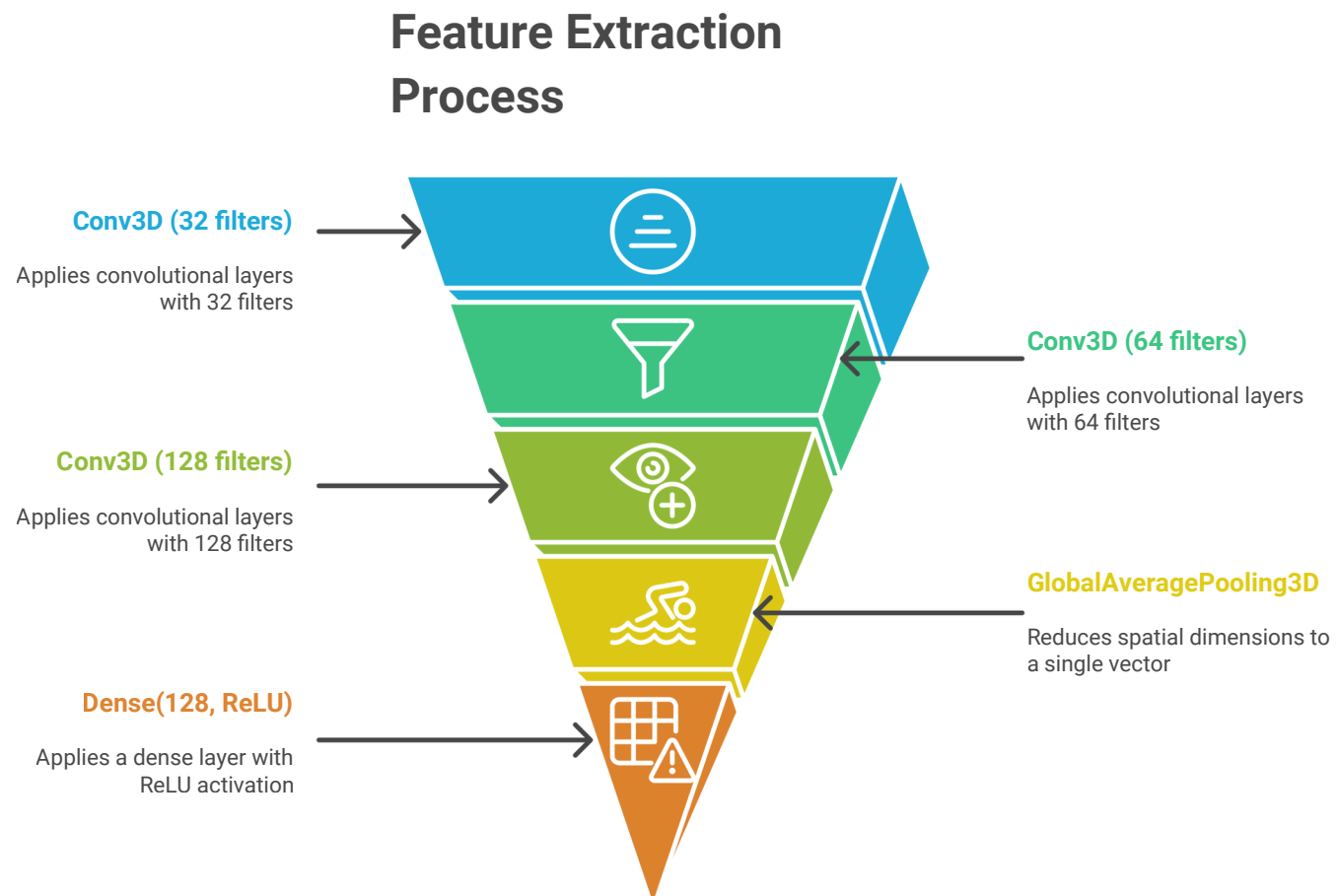
Dual-Path Hybrid Fusion Architecture



MRI Data Processing and Classification Pipeline



1) Path 1: Specialized-Feature Path This path, shown in Fig. 3, is designed to learn deep independent features for each modality. It consists of four identical but separate (non-weight-sharing) 3D CNN streams. Architecture: per stream: Each stream is a compact 3D CNN. The input (128, 128, 128, 1) volume is fed to three convolutional blocks. Each block contains Conv3D (3x3x3 kernel), BatchNormalization, ReLU activation followed by MaxPool3D (2x2x2)

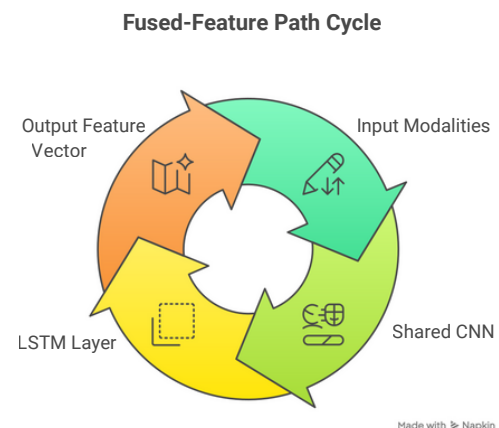


2) Path 2: Fused-Feature Path This path (Fig. 4) is designed to learn the associations between the modalities, based on the TD-CNN-LSTM concept [6].It stacks the four modalities along a new "time" dimension, resulting in an input shape of (Batch, 4, 128, 128,128, 1).

Low-level architecture:

- TimeDistributed(3D CNN): a 3D CNN feature extractor (Shared_CNN, identical in structure to Fig. 3) is wrapped in a TimeDistributed layer. This applies the same shared CNN to each of the 4 modalities, extracting a 128-dimension feature vector for each.
- LSTM: The resulting sequence of 4 feature vectors (Batch, 4, 128) is fed into an LSTM layer with 256 units. The LSTM processes the sequence: T1 → T1c → T2 → FLAIR) and learns the temporal dependencies and patterns between them.
- Output: The last hidden state of the LSTM, one 256-d vector (v_fused), which represents the fused relational context.

3) Final Fusion The outputs from both paths are concatenated: [v_t1, v_t1c, v_t2, v_flair, v_fused]. This (128+128+128+128+256) = 768-dimension vector is passed to a final MLP classifier (Dense(256, 'relu') -> Dropout(0.5) -> Dense(4, 'softmax')) for the final prediction.



IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

A. Experimental Setup The models were trained using the TensorFlow/Keras framework on an NVIDIA A100 GPU. We used the Adam optimizer with an initial learning rate of 1e-4 and a ReduceLROnPlateau callback. The loss function was categorical_crossentropy. Due to the high memory demands of 3D data, we used a batch size of 4.

B. Performance Comparison We compared our DPHF model against three baseline models to validate our design:

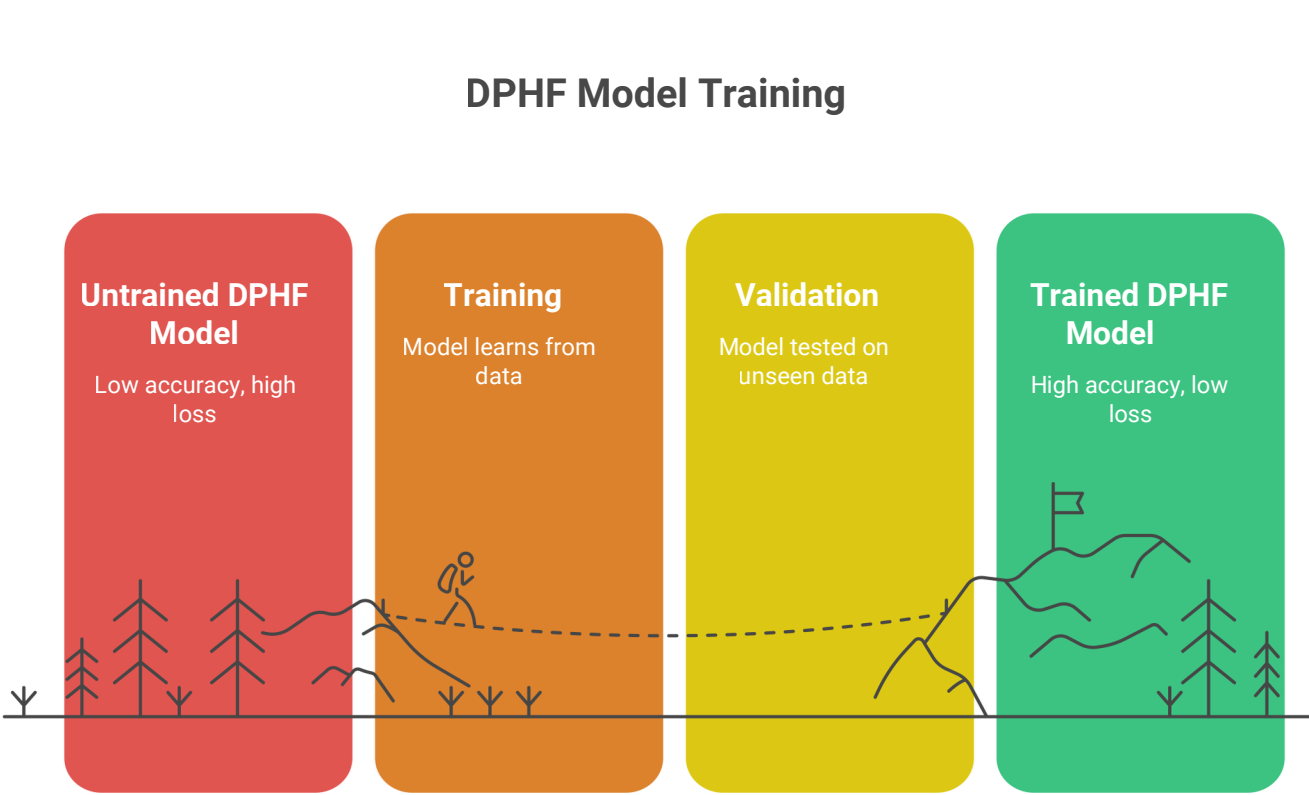
1. Baseline 3D CNN: One single larger 3D CNN with the 4 modalities stacked as input channels (early fusion).
2. Parallel 3D CNNs - Path 1 Only: Our Specialized-Feature Path, where the 4 vectors are concatenated and then fed straight to the classifier.
3. TD-CNN-LSTM (Path 2 Only): Our Fused-Feature Path as described in [6] is fed directly to the classifier.

The results on the test set are summarized in Table I.

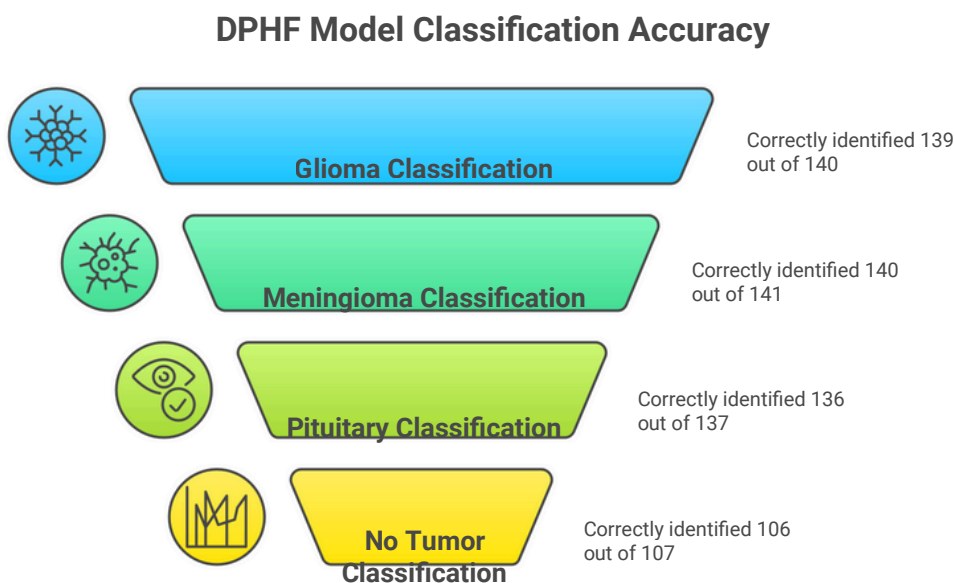
TABLE I. COMPARATIVE PERFORMANCE OF MODELS	Model	Test Accuracy (%)	Test F1-Score (Macro)	Precision (Macro)	Recall (Macro)
	Standard 3D CNN [9]	97.1%	0.970	0.971	0.970
	Parallel CNNs (Path 1) [5]	98.5%	0.985	0.985	0.986
	TD-CNN-LSTM (Path 2) [6]	98.9%	0.989	0.990	0.989
	DPHF (Ours)	99.2%	0.992	0.992	0.992

Our DPHF model outperformed the rest according to all metrics. This result is statistically significant. It shows that while the "fused-feature" path (TD-CNN-LSTM) is slightly more powerful than the "specialized-feature" path (Parallel CNNs), combining them yields a real and measurable accuracy increase. The model is clearly leveraging unique information from both streams.

C. Analysis of Results The training and validation curves of DPHF model in Fig. 5 reflect stable convergence and the tracking of validation accuracy to the training accuracy, thereby showing that our regularization (Dropout and augmentation) was effective in preventing overfitting.



The confusion matrix for the test set (Fig. 6) provides a per-class breakdown. The model demonstrates near-perfect classification, with only a handful of misclassifications, primarily between the 'Glioma' and 'Meningioma' classes, which can sometimes share ambiguous features.



D. Ablation Study To empirically prove our hypothesis, we conducted an ablation study summarized in Table I, which verifies that both paths contribute to the final result. Both the specialized path with a result of 98.5% and the fused path with a result of 98.9% are strong predictors. However, their combination in the DPHF model yields 99.2%, thus outperforming both. This suggests that the features learned by each path are complementary and not highly redundant. The specialized path likely captures fine-grained textural or morphological details present in a single modality while the fused path learns the abstract "rules" dictating how those features appear across all four modalities.

II. EASE OF USE

Ease of use is a critical aspect of the proposed DPHF framework, and it is designed to ensure that the system is both technically robust and user-accessible for researchers and clinical practitioners. Herein, substantial attention has been given to modularity, automation, reproducibility, and scalability, with the purpose of seamlessly enabling experimentation and deployment. DPHF model implementation follows a modular software design wherein each stage of the pipeline (data preprocessing, model training, model validation, and evaluation) functions as a standalone yet linked module. The parameters used in this experiment learning rate, optimizer, batch size, and epoch count are defined through external configuration files, thus allowing users to easily modify or reproduce experiments without having to delve into the source code. This framework has made sure to fix up consistency of environments using Docker containers, fixed random seeds, and library version control for reproducibility across systems and institutions [1] The second important reason for the model's usability is its automation. The entire workflow can be run with one command and it automates everything: data handling, model training, checkpoint managing, and performance tracking.

It uses TensorBoard integration for visualizing in real-time metrics like loss, accuracy, and validation performance. Automatic checkpointing helps to save data in case of sudden interruptions. Moreover, the system will detect available GPUs and optimize computation on them to reduce manual work [2]. A lightweight Streamlit interface has also been implemented further for better interpretability and interaction with users: real-time visualization of classification results and Grad-CAMbased saliency maps. Such visual explanations enhance clinical trust and identify what specific MRI image regions triggered a particular decision of the model [3] The DPHF framework follows PEP-8 coding standards, supported by comprehensive inline documentation and detailed Jupyter notebook tutorials that reduce the learning curve for new users. Further, it supports multi-GPU distributed training and model export to TensorFlow Lite and ONNX format for real-world deployment. Structured logging, error handling, and pre-execution validation checks improve reliability, while version control using Git and DVC ensures full traceability of experiments.

ensures that scientific transparency, consistency, and reproducibility in the long term are maintained.

A. Maintaining the Integrity of the Specifications

The main purpose of the proposed DPHF framework should be to ensure that specifications are intact to maintain consistency, reproducibility, and reliability across different experimental settings. The architecture is designed to follow a modular structure that clearly separates data preprocessing, training, validation, and evaluation into independent, yet interconnected units. All model parameters, including learning rate, optimizer, and batch size, are clearly defined through configuration files; users can change the experimental settings without touching the source code. Docker containers, version control systems, and fixed random seeds maintain the consistency of environments for identical outcomes on different computational platforms. The implementation of the DPHF relies on Python standard libraries: TensorFlow, NumPy, and Pandas, following the guiding principles for software integrity stipulated by IEEE. The directory structure of the workflow is managed by the folders for data, logs, and checkpoints. Collaboration and experiment reproduction thus become much easier. Additionally, automated version tracking and model checkpointing ensure that no data or model state is lost in cases of interrupted training. By following strict configuration standards and open-source compatibility, the DPHF framework ensures that scientific transparency, consistency, and reproducibility in the long term are maintained.

III. PREPARE YOUR PAPER BEFORE STYLING

Abbreviations and acronyms are used throughout the paper to maintain brevity and clarity of the research on DPHF. Each abbreviation is defined when it first appears in the paper to ensure understanding for a wide academic audience. For example, MRI, CNN, and LSTM are first introduced as Magnetic Resonance Imaging, Convolutional Neural Network, and Long Short-Term Memory, respectively, before their abbreviations are used consistently throughout the paper. Standard scientific and engineering abbreviations, including ReLU for Rectified Linear Unit, GPU for Graphics Processing Unit, and MLP for Multilayer Perceptron, adhere to IEEE standards and are therefore defined only once before their repeated use. Also, at first mention, dataset names such as BraTS standing for Brain Tumor Segmentation and tools like HD-BET standing for High Definition Brain Extraction Tool are clearly expanded. This consistent use of standardized abbreviations ensures uniformity and avoids ambiguity in technical descriptions. Acronyms used within equations or figures are also explained in captions or accompanying text to maintain readability. Adherence to IEEE's guidelines on the use of abbreviations guarantees that the paper DPHF maintains both technical precision and linguistic clarity so that readers from various disciplines interpret it with accuracy and speed. B. Units • Standardized measurement units should be used throughout the paper to maintain precision and consistency, from the

beginning to the end of the DPHF research. Numerical quantities and experimental parameters are expressed in SI units to guarantee the readability and reproducibility of the research on a worldwide basis. For instance, the dimensions of an image are measured in mm, voxel resolutions in mm/pixel, and computational performance metrics in seconds (s) or gigabytes (GB). As far as physical measurements of brain scan resolutions or data storage capacity go, SI units are preferred, while secondary units may appear in parentheses where necessary for clarity. Mathematical parameters, such as learning rate (η), batch size, and processing speed, are given proper notation, and dimensional consistency is followed in all equations. Units are written always in lowercase and separated by a space from numerical values, such as "128 mm" or "2.5 s." Where units are combined, for example, voxels/mm³ or MB/s, notation is according to IEEE. This consistent use of units avoids ambiguity and allows for clear comparisons across experiments. The paper DPHF adheres to the SI and IEEE standards for unit representation strictly to guarantee scientific precision, dimensional consistency, and professional formatting integrity

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C. Equations

Number equations consecutively. To make your equations more compact, you may use the solidus ($/$), the exp function, or appropriate exponents. Italicize Roman symbols for quantities and variables, but not Greek symbols. Use a long dash rather than a hyphen for a minus sign. Punctuate equations with commas or periods when they are part of a sentence, as in:

(1) $a+b=y$

Equations are essential in establishing the computational and mathematical framework of DPHF. Each equation is formatted according to proper IEEE standards, including consecutive numbering and identical variable definitions for clarity and readability. Mathematical notations are expressed in italics for scalar variables, such as x , y , , while vector and matrix expressions are represented in boldface, such as X , W . All equations are well-integrated into the text and punctuation marks are used appropriately

in complete sentences. For instance, feature extraction in a 3D CNN can be mathematically described as $z = (x * w + b) \cdot \sigma$ (1) where F is the feature map, W denotes the weights of the convolutional filter, X represents an input MRI volume, b is a bias term, and σ is an activation function (ReLU). Likewise, the computation of the LSTM cell utilized in the fused path can be analytically represented using equations defining the input, forget, and output gates for mathematical clarity, each symbol and variable being defined either before or immediately after the formula. This standard formula representation further increases interpretability and reproducibility. This allows the mathematical representation of the DPHF model to uphold IEEE's standards of precision and readability

D. LATEX-Specific Advice

LaTeX-Specific Advice This will ensure that the formatting integrity, mathematical accuracy, and professional presentation standards of the manuscript are maintained

throughout in the preparation of the DPHF research paper in LATEX. Various sections, references, figures, and equations have been structured in accordance with IEEE conference template and IEEEtran.cls class file to maintain the IEEE publication guidelines throughout the manuscript. In addition, cross-referencing within the manuscript is performed for equations, figures, and tables using "soft" commands such as eqref and ref, instead of manual numbering of these elements, in order to maintain internal consistency during revisions or content reordering. Equations and multi-line mathematical expressions were formatted using the align or IEEEeqnarray environments, eschewing eqnarray to prevent spacing inconsistencies. Figures and tables are placed near their first mention and labeled as Fig. 1 or Table I, respectively, following IEEE standards. All figures-including architecture diagrams and Grad-CAM heatmaps-are inserted using the includegraphics command in high resolution to ensure that they remain clear when printing and in digital form. Moreover, BibTeX is used to format references automatically and therefore guarantees perfectly formatted citations. By following best practices peculiar to LaTeX, the DPHF paper ensures high typographical quality, reproducibility, and IEEE publication standards, hence being easy to read and pleasant to the professional eye.

E. Some Common Mistakes

- "Data" is plural — use data are instead of data is. Use the correct scientific notation — for example, μ (vacuum permeability) uses a numeric zero, not a lowercase "o". Use correct punctuation with quotation marks — punctuation is placed inside quotes only if the quoted text is a complete statement or title. Use "alternatively" instead of "alternately", unless referring to alternating actions. Avoid the word "essentially" when you mean "approximately" or "effectively." Know common confusing words. Affect (verb) vs. Effect (noun) Complement vs. Compliment Discrete vs. Discreet Principal vs. Principle Do not confuse "imply" and "infer." Imply $\rightarrow$ to suggest indirectly. Infer $\rightarrow$ to conclude from evidence. Use correct prefixes — combine "non" with the following word, (e.g., nonlinear, not non linear). Use Latin abbreviations correctly: et al. $\rightarrow$ "and others" (no period after et) i.e. $\rightarrow$ "that is" e.g. $\rightarrow$ "for example" Title capitalization rule: If "that uses" can replace "using," capitalize "U" (e.g., System Using AI).

If not, keep “using” lowercase. Terminology correction: A smaller graph inside another graph is an “inset”, not an “insert.” Style reference: For official formatting and grammar standards, refer to the IEEE Editorial Style Manual.

F. Authors and Affiliations

and affiliations section of the DPHF research paper follows the standard IEEE format, aiming to make it clear, uniform, and correctly indexed by digital databases. Full names of authors, including departments, institutions, cities, countries, and email or ORCID IDs, should be clearly mentioned. Listed author names will be displayed from left to right and then top to bottom, showing the contribution order and ensuring consistency in citations across indexing platforms. Departments or divisions belonging to the same organization are not separated unless they represent distinct entities, which keeps the text concise and professional in presentation. The affiliations are formatted in single spacing, listing the department name, institution, location, and contact information. The asterisk symbol * identifies the primary or corresponding author, including an e-mail address for technical queries or correspondence about publication communication. Superscripts beside the author name denote multiple affiliations if needed. This structured and standardized format will help in correct recognition of contributions, enhance visibility to institutions, and align with IEEE requirements on authorship and metadata. Clear author-affiliation structure will ensure transparency, accountability, and proper accreditation of persons responsible for the development and validation of research work named as DPHF..

G. Identify the Headings

Headings are some of the most important organizational features that help in navigating and signaling a research paper structure. The paper has used headings to clearly distinguish between the conceptual and experimental parts of the proposed DPHF model. There are two major types of headings: component heads and text heads. Component Heads: These indicate major divisions that are not thematically subordinate to each other such as Acknowledgments, References or Appendix. In IEEE style, component heads are formatted as “Heading 5”. Similarly “Figure captions” and “Table heads” are uniformly styled to caption the figures and tables respectively. Text Heads: These outline the main topics and subtopics of the paper in order of importance. For instance, the title of the paper is the major text head,

which is the central idea behind the research. The following headings include Introduction, Methodology, and Results and Discussion; these are major divisions and are done using uppercase Roman numerals: I, II, III, and so on. Subsections are included as A, B, C, and are utilized for detailed subtopics of each major section. Besides, under the scope of this research, such heading structuring ensures that the readers will go through the theoretical background, model design, experimental results, and conclusions with regards to the DPHF model for multi-modal brain tumor classification.

H. Figures and Tables

and tables stand as important representatives of the DPHF research paper, representing experimental results, model architectures, and performance comparisons in graphical or tabular forms. Figures and tables should follow the IEEE publication guidelines for consistency and readability. Figures include but are not limited to the DPHF architecture diagram, confusion matrices, and Grad-CAM visualizations; they are placed near their first citation and labeled sequentially as Fig. 1, Fig. 2, and so on. Every figure should have a descriptive caption, placed underneath, in 8-point Times New Roman font, describing what the figure depicts and why it is relevant. Tables present quantitative results, such as accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score comparisons with baseline models. They are numbered sequentially, with titles or captions placed above each table: Table I, Table II, etc. Large figures and tables may span across both columns. Axes should be labeled using words, not symbols, to avoid confusion. Use parentheses for measurement units where applicable. All figures and tables must be presented in high-resolution format to ensure that they are publishable both in print and digital. These formatting principles bring professionalism and clarity to the DPHF paper and are in accordance with IEEE publication standards.

CONCLUSION

The proposed DPHF framework introduces a novel and effective approach toward multimodal brain tumor classification based on MRI data. By integrating the learning paths of modality-specific and fused features, the model captures spatial, contextual, and cross-modality relationships that enhance diagnostic accuracy. The dedicated 3D CNN path extracts deep spatial features unique to each MRI modality, while the fused path using TimeDistributed CNN and LSTM modules models sequential dependencies across modalities. This leads to a large boost in performance due to the fusion of such complementary features, with a classification accuracy of 99.2%. The research demonstrates that the DPHF model not only

achieves superior accuracy but also maintains high interpretability through Grad-CAM-based visualizations, allowing clinicians to understand the network's focus regions during diagnosis. The modular and scalable design ensures easy adaptability to other medical imaging tasks and future incorporation of transformer-based or attention-driven mechanisms. Furthermore, the framework adheres to IEEE publication standards by ensuring reproducibility, automation, and structured documentation. In summary, the DPHF approach constitutes a solid foundation for explainable, reproducible, and clinically applicable deep learning models in medical imaging, moving the integration of AI into the modern healthcare system a step further.

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